

Complex Ellipsis and Substitution

C2 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

Ellipsis (omitting words that are recoverable from context) and substitution (replacing repeated words with a short pro-form) make advanced English tighter and more natural, avoiding clumsy repetition.

- a) Ellipsis in reduced clauses — omitting a repeated subject, auxiliary, or verb when the meaning stays clear.
- - After "and/but/or" in parallel structures: She ordered coffee and [she ordered] a croissant.
- - In comparative/contrastive clauses: He works harder than she [works]. / Some like tea; others [like] coffee.
- - After auxiliaries, when the main verb is recoverable: He hasn't finished yet, but he will [finish] soon.
- - In subordinate clauses with the same subject as the main clause: While [he was] waiting, he read the newspaper.
- b) Omission patterns common in academic and literary writing — dropping relative pronouns and "that" in defining clauses, and omitting "which is/who is" before a reduced participle or adjective phrase.

The book [that] I mentioned is finally out. / The results, [which were] published last year, remain controversial.

- c) Pro-forms in complex texts — using "do so," "one," "the same," "such," or simple auxiliaries to stand in for a whole verb phrase or idea already mentioned, avoiding repetition across sentences.

He asked her to leave, and she did so immediately. (= she left immediately)

If you need a pen, take one from my desk. (= a pen, not a specific one already mentioned)

The results confirmed the hypothesis; subsequent studies have done the same.

These devices are essential for sounding genuinely native-like: overusing full repetition, even when grammatically correct, sounds stilted at C2.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. She likes jazz, and her brother does too.
- 2. He hasn't called yet, but he probably will soon.
- 3. Some prefer working from home; others don't.
- 4. While waiting for the bus, she finished her book.
- 5. The report [that] we discussed yesterday has been revised.
- 6. The proposal, [which was] submitted last month, is still under review.
- 7. He asked me to stay quiet, and I did so, reluctantly.
- 8. If you need an umbrella, take one from the stand by the door.

- 9. The first study confirmed the theory; the second one did the same.
- 10. She can speak French fluently, and so can her sister.
- 11. He wanted to leave early, but couldn't.
- 12. Whatever the outcome, we'll accept it.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: She likes jazz, and her brother does it too.

Correct: She likes jazz, and her brother does too. (or: ...and so does her brother.)

Why: "Does too" alone functions as the substitute verb phrase — adding "it" creates redundancy.

- 2. Incorrect: He hasn't called yet, but he will do it soon.

Correct: He hasn't called yet, but he will soon. / ...but he will do so soon.

Why: Use the bare auxiliary or "do so," not "will do it," which is redundant/informal here.

- 3. Incorrect: While she was waiting, was reading a magazine.

Correct: While waiting, she was reading a magazine. / While she was waiting, she was reading a magazine.

Why: If you omit the subject after "while," you must also omit "was" (ellipsis applies to subject + auxiliary together); otherwise, keep both.

- 4. Incorrect: If you need a pen, take the one from my desk. (when no specific pen has been mentioned)

Correct: If you need a pen, take one from my desk.

Why: "One" (indefinite substitution) is used for an unspecified item; "the one" implies a specific, previously identified item.

- 5. Incorrect: He asked her to apologize, and she did so it.

Correct: He asked her to apologize, and she did so.

Why: "Did so" already replaces the whole verb phrase — don't add another object after it.

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (complete with the correct ellipsis/substitution or write "—" if a word should be omitted)
- 1. He plays the guitar, and his sister ____ too.
- 2. She hasn't finished the report, but she ____ by Friday.
- 3. ____ waiting for the results, they kept refreshing the page.
- 4. If you need a chair, grab ____ from the next room.
- 5. The plan worked in the first city; it ____ in the second.

- 6. He told them to wait, and they ____.
- 7. Some people love spicy food; ____ can't stand it.
- 8. The book ____ you recommended was excellent.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (rewrite each pair using ellipsis or substitution to avoid repetition)
- 1. My father can cook well. My mother can cook well too.
- 2. He hasn't decided yet, but he will decide soon.
- 3. She was reading while she was waiting for the train.
- 4. The first experiment succeeded. The second experiment succeeded too.
- 5. If you want a coffee, take a coffee from the machine.
- 6. He told me to relax, and I relaxed.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. She likes hiking, and her friend does it too.
- 2. While she was cooking, was listening to music.
- 3. He asked me to stop, and I did so it.
- 4. If you need a towel, take the one from the shelf. (no towel mentioned before)
- 5. He hasn't replied yet, but he will do it tomorrow.
- 6. The first plan failed; the second plan did the same it.
- D. Guided Production
- 1. Write two sentences about two people with a shared habit, using "does/did too" or "so does/did."
- 2. Write one sentence with a reduced clause after "while" or "when," omitting the repeated subject.
- 3. Write one sentence using "do so" to substitute for a whole action already mentioned.
- 4. Write one sentence using indefinite "one" to substitute for an unspecified item.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. does
- 2. will (or: will have finished)
- 3. While (with subject/auxiliary omitted: While waiting for...)
- 4. one
- 5. did (also worked / did so)
- 6. did
- 7. others
- 8. — (that/which omitted: The book you recommended...)
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
- 1. My father can cook well, and so can my mother. / ...and my mother can too.
- 2. He hasn't decided yet, but he will soon.
- 3. She was reading while waiting for the train.
- 4. The first experiment succeeded, and so did the second.
- 5. If you want a coffee, take one from the machine.
- 6. He told me to relax, and I did.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. She likes hiking, and her friend does too.
- 2. While cooking, she was listening to music. / While she was cooking, she was listening to music.
- 3. He asked me to stop, and I did so.

- 4. If you need a towel, take one from the shelf.
- 5. He hasn't replied yet, but he will soon. / ...but he will do so tomorrow.
- 6. The first plan failed; the second did the same.
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
- 1. My brother loves horror films, and so do I. My sister, on the other hand, does not.
- 2. When traveling alone, I always feel more observant of my surroundings.
- 3. The manager asked everyone to submit their reports early, and most people did so without complaint.
- 4. If you ever need a notebook, just grab one from the supply cabinet.

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